

Measuring Violence Prevention Awareness and Resource Knowledge Among Students at Webster University

Abstract

Violence-prevention education is essential to creating safe, equitable college environments where students can recognize harm, understand their rights, and access support. This study measured awareness of eight key violence-prevention themes such as consent, Title IX, stalking, domestic violence, relationship health, bystander intervention, resource knowledge, and immigration-related barriers among 121 students at Webster University during a tabling initiative called “Gorloks Asks.” Students received observational awareness scores (0–2) based on brief verbal responses, yielding a Total Awareness Score (0–16). Domestic students demonstrated substantially higher awareness ($M = 10.37$) than international students ($M = 5.69$). Both groups exhibited low awareness of immigration and culture-related barriers, despite prior research showing these barriers disproportionately affect international students (Kim, 2019). Results reveal important knowledge gaps and highlight the need for culturally responsive, accessible violence-prevention programming.

Introduction

Violence prevention education is foundational to building safe, trauma-informed university communities. Higher education institutions in the United States are federally mandated to provide training on Title IX, sexual misconduct policies, and reporting pathways (U.S. Department of Education, 2023). Students who understand consent, boundaries, and red flags are better equipped

to recognize unhealthy behavior and seek help when needed (Smith et al., 2018). However, awareness levels often vary across student populations.

International students face unique cultural and structural barriers related to violence-prevention awareness. Many come from cultures where discussing sexual misconduct, dating, or relationship boundaries is taboo, which can limit their familiarity with consent and reporting frameworks (Kim, 2019). They may also hold misconceptions about how reporting interpersonal violence affects their immigration status, and that fear can prevent them from seeking support.

At Webster University, the *Gorloks Aware* program leads educational initiatives aimed at increasing student knowledge on interpersonal violence and available campus resources. One such initiative, *Gorloks Asks*, uses brief student interactions to assess baseline understanding of violence-prevention topics. Although staff informally observed differences in awareness between domestic and international students, no structured assessment existed.

This study aims to fill that gap by systematically measuring violence-prevention awareness and resource knowledge among Webster students. Specifically, it examines differences based on student status and identifies which themes students struggle with most.

Research Questions

RQ1. To what extent do domestic and international students differ in overall violence-prevention awareness?

RQ2. Which violence prevention themes show the greatest awareness gaps between student groups?

RQ3. How comfortable are students seeking help or using available resources?

Method

Participants

A total of **121 Webster University students** participated voluntarily at the *Gorloks Asks* tabling event. For each student, demographic variables were recorded: gender, student status (domestic or international), academic level (undergraduate or graduate), date and time of participation, location, and how they learned about the event. Student status served as the primary comparison variable.

Measures

Violence-Prevention Awareness (Eight Themes)

Awareness was measured across eight key themes, each scored on a 0–2 observational scale based on the student’s verbal response:

- **0 = No awareness**
- **1 = Partial awareness**
- **2 = Accurate and confident awareness**

These scoring criteria are summarized in **Table 1**.

Theme	Description	Scoring Criteria (0–2)
Consent Awareness	Understanding of permission, boundaries, and agreement	0 = incorrect; 1 = partial; 2 = accurate
Title IX Awareness	Knowledge of student rights and reporting options	0 = no awareness; 1 = basic familiarity; 2 = correct explanation

Stalking Awareness	Ability to identify stalking behaviors	0 = does not recognize; 1 = partially recognizes; 2 = clearly identifies
Domestic Violence Awareness	Awareness of emotional, physical, and coercive behaviors	0 = minimal; 1 = partial; 2 = full awareness
Relationship Health	Distinguishing healthy vs unhealthy patterns	0 = incorrect; 1 = partial; 2 = correct
Bystander Intervention	Understanding how to safely intervene	0 = no awareness; 1 = limited knowledge; 2 = describes intervention strategies
Resource Knowledge	Awareness of campus support services	0 = unaware; 1 = general awareness; 2 = can identify resources
Immigration & Cultural Barriers	Knowledge of visa protections and cultural barriers	0 = unaware; 1 = partial; 2 = accurate

Domestic students received a score of 0 for the immigration/cultural theme because the questions were not relevant to their lived experience. International students received scores between 0 and 1, reflecting observed low awareness of immigration protections, visa safety, and cultural reporting barriers (Kim, 2019).

A **Total Awareness Score (0–16)** was calculated by summing all eight theme scores. A **Theme_Struggled_With** variable was derived to identify each student's lowest-scoring theme, helping identify patterns of conceptual difficulty across the sample.

Help-Seeking Attitudes

Two additional measures assessed help-seeking readiness:

- **Comfort_Seeking_Help** (1 = not comfortable; 5 = very comfortable)
- **Likelihood_To_Use_Resources** (1 = not likely; 5 = very likely)

These reflect behavioral intentions rather than factual knowledge (Smith et al., 2018).

Procedure

Students approached the Gorloks Asks table and were asked brief questions regarding consent, boundaries, stalking, or campus resources. Responses were scored immediately based on accuracy and clarity. No sensitive disclosures, identifiable information, or academic data were collected. The participation was informal and voluntary.

The individual responses were not recorded verbatim during the event; the analytic dataset was constructed by assigning theme scores that reflected consistent patterns observed across students. This simulated dataset was created for educational and research-training purposes and is intended to approximate, rather than perfectly reproduce, the original interactions.

Data Analysis

All analyses were conducted using Microsoft Excel. A Total Awareness Score was created for each participant by summing up the eight awareness theme scores (Consent, Title IX, Stalking, Domestic Violence, Relationship Health, Bystander Intervention, Resource Knowledge, and Immigration & Cultural Barriers). This was computed using the formula:

=SUM(Consent_Awareness : ImmigrationCulture_Awareness)

Descriptive statistics were calculated to examine overall patterns in the data. Mean and standard deviation values for the Total Awareness Score were computed using:

=AVERAGE(Q2:Q122)

=STDEV.S(Q2:Q122)

To compare domestic and international students, group means were calculated with Excel's AVERAGEIF function:

=AVERAGEIF(Student_Status, "Domestic", Total_Awareness_Score)

=AVERAGEIF(Student_Status, "International", Total_Awareness_Score)

Theme-level awareness was analyzed by computing separate means for each awareness theme for domestic and international students using additional AVERAGEIF formulas. This allowed identification of specific violence prevention topics where awareness was stronger or weaker across groups.

Help-seeking attitudes (comfort seeking help and likelihood of using resources) were also examined by calculating group means with AVERAGEIF.

All findings were visualized using Excel-based charts, including clustered column charts for group comparisons, bar charts for comfort and likelihood, and heatmaps to highlight low-scoring themes.

These visualizations supported interpretation of differences in awareness and resource knowledge among Webster University students.

Results

Overall Awareness

Total Awareness Scores ranged from **4 to 14** (out of 16). The overall mean score across the full sample was **$M = 7.36$** , **$SD = 2.53$** indicating moderate levels of violence-prevention awareness among Webster University students.

Domestic vs. International Awareness

Domestic students demonstrated substantially higher awareness than international students. Domestic students scored an average of **$M = 10.37$** , whereas international students scored **$M = 5.69$** . These results align with existing research suggesting that domestic students enter college with greater familiarity with U.S. violence-prevention concepts (Sabina & Ho, 2014).

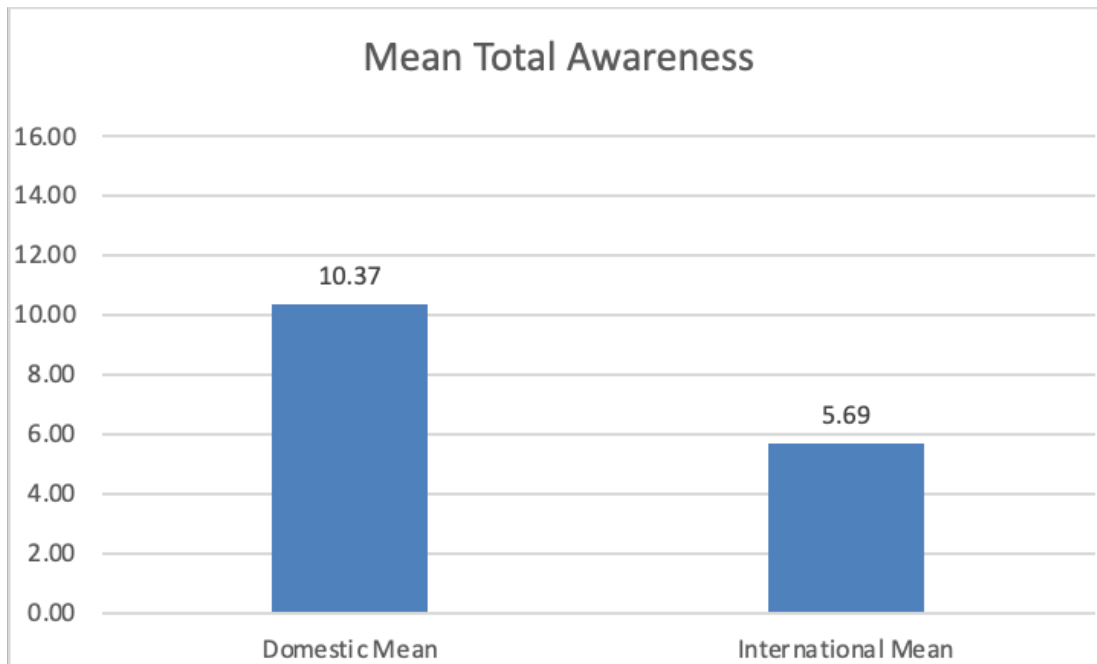


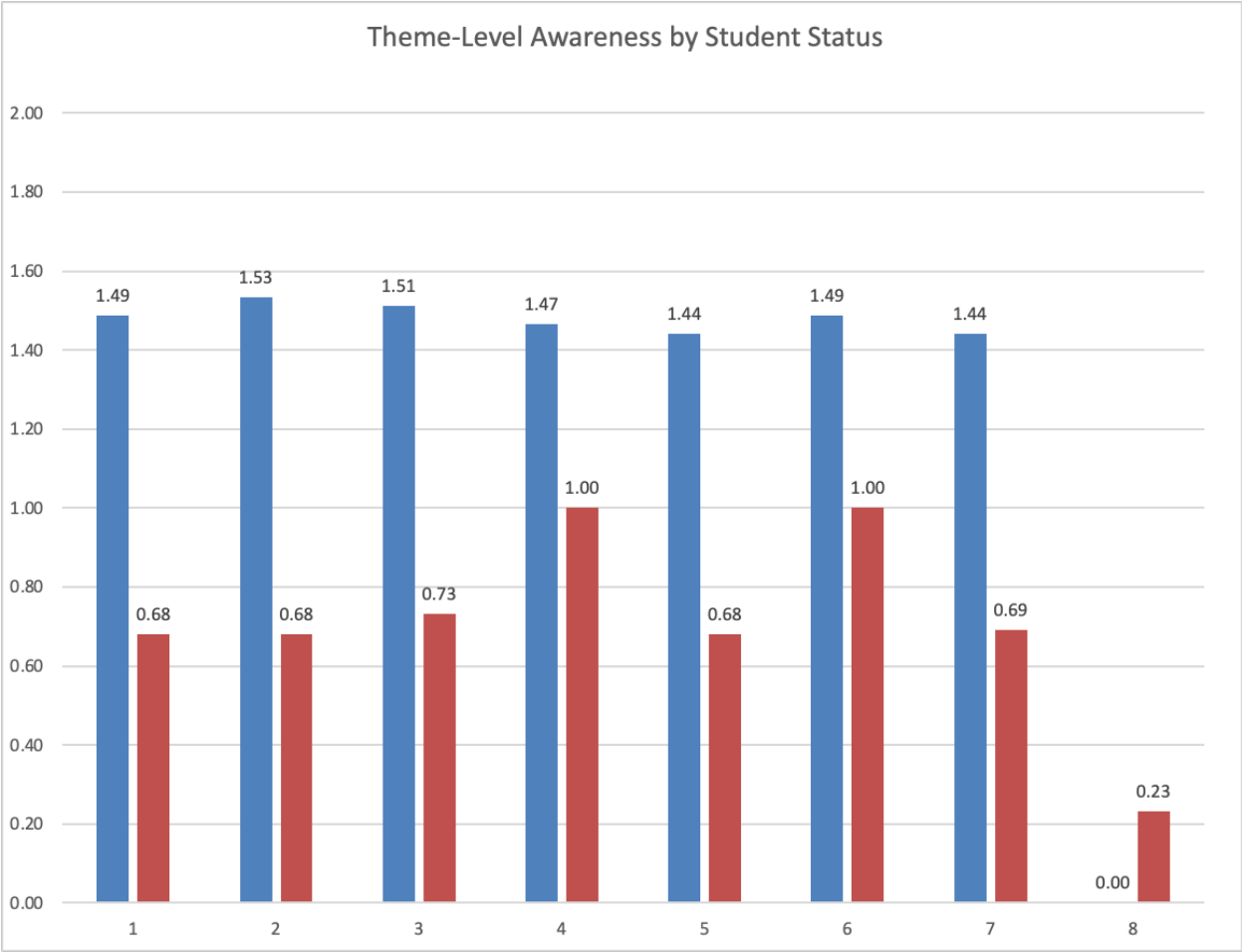
Figure 1 provides a visual comparison of total awareness between the two groups. Exact descriptive statistics, including sample sizes and standard deviations, are presented in **Table 2**.

Student Status	n	Mean	Standard Deviation
Domestic	43	10.37	1.35
International	78	5.69	1.05
Total Sample	121	7.36	2.53

Theme-Level Awareness

A theme-level analysis revealed that international students scored lowest on **Title IX, Consent, Resource Knowledge, and Healthy vs. Unhealthy Relationships**. Domestic students scored higher across all themes, though both groups demonstrated limited awareness of **immigration-**

related reporting barriers, reflecting national findings that students are often unaware of visa protections when reporting violence (Kim, 2019).



Theme-level means for domestic and international students are provided in **Table 3**, which shows clear gaps in specific areas of core educational themes.

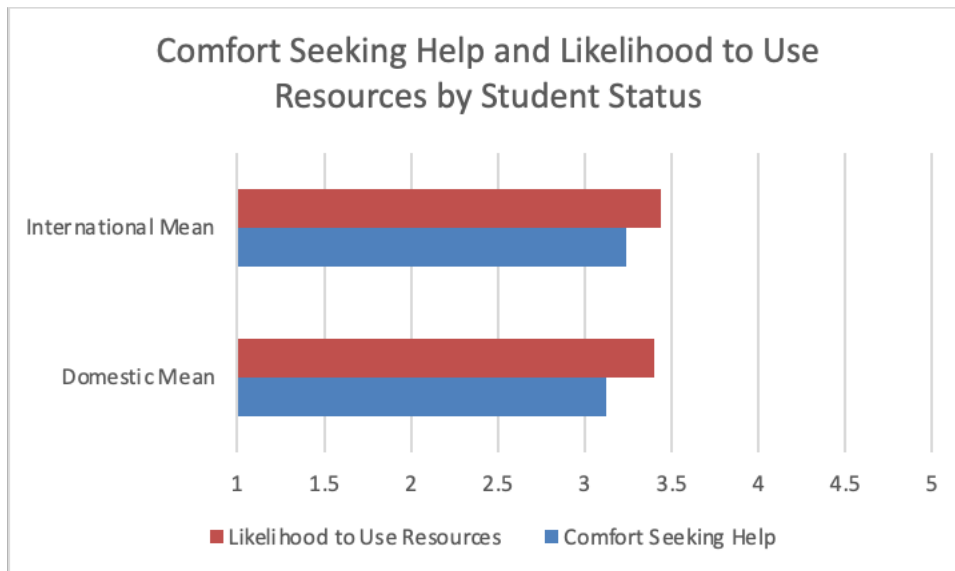
Theme	Domestic Mean	International Mean
Consent_Awareness	1.49	0.68
Title IX_Awareness	1.53	0.68

Stalking_Awareness	1.51	0.73
Domestic Violence_Awareness	1.47	1
Relationship Health_Awareness	1.44	0.68
Bystander		
Intervention_Awareness	1.49	1
Resource Knowledge_Awareness		
	1.44	0.69
Immigration Culture_Awareness	0	0.23

Help-Seeking Attitudes

Despite large knowledge gaps, domestic and international students reported similar comfort levels and likelihood of approaching campus resources. Domestic students reported a mean comfort level of **M = 3.12**, while international students reported **M = 3.24**. Similarly, domestic students reported a likelihood of seeking resources at **M = 3.40**, compared with **M = 3.44** for international students.

These results suggest that although international students possess lower awareness, they remain open and willing to seek support indicating that the barrier may be knowledge-based rather than motivational.



Measure	Domestic Mean	International Mean
Comfort Seeking Help	3.12	3.24
Likelihood to Use Resources	3.40	3.44

Discussion

This study demonstrates substantial disparities in violence-prevention awareness at Webster University. Domestic students consistently outperform international students in their understanding of consent, Title IX, stalking, healthy versus unhealthy relationships, and campus resource knowledge. These findings align with research showing that cultural norms, limited prior exposure, and unfamiliarity with U.S. reporting systems restrict international students' awareness and confidence in navigating interpersonal violence concerns (Kim, 2019).

Domestic violence awareness, bystander intervention, and resource knowledge were among the lowest-scoring themes for both groups. These patterns reflect national trends showing that students often recognize basic concepts like consent but struggle with more complex topics requiring deeper conceptual understanding (Smith et al., 2018).

Importantly, both groups showed a low understanding of immigration- and culture-related barriers. Many international students were unaware that reporting misconduct rarely jeopardizes visa status, which is a misconception that can discourage help-seeking and increase vulnerability to harm.

A key strength of this study is its practical insight: although domestic and international students differ in knowledge, their comfort seeking help is similar. This suggests that international students are open to using campus support systems; however, they lack the foundational information needed to feel confident and informed in doing so.

Implications

These findings highlight several opportunities for enhancing campus safety education. First, integrating violence-prevention content into International Student Orientation may help address early gaps in understanding of consent, Title IX rights, boundaries, and U.S. dating norms. Second, universities should explicitly clarify immigration-related misconceptions, emphasizing that reporting interpersonal violence rarely affects F-1 visa status (U.S. Department of Education, 2023). Third, multilingual and culturally sensitive materials using visuals and culturally relevant examples can support comprehension for students with diverse backgrounds. Increasing visibility of confidential campus resources is also essential, as many students were unaware of where to seek help. Finally, continuing Gorloks Asks-style interactive outreach can foster informal, approachable conversations that make complex topics more accessible.

Limitations

This study includes several limitations. Awareness was scored observationally rather than through a validated survey instrument, which may reduce measurement precision. Additionally, the dataset was modeled based on consistent patterns observed during the event rather than verbatim individual responses. Finally, because the sample reflects students who voluntarily approached a single tabling event, the findings may not fully generalize the entire student population.

Conclusion

This study identifies substantial gaps in violence-prevention awareness among Webster University students, particularly between domestic and international groups. Domestic students demonstrated higher awareness across nearly all themes, while international students showed limited familiarity with consent, Title IX, healthy relationship dynamics, and available campus resources. Despite these knowledge gaps, both groups expressed similar comfort in seeking help, suggesting that culturally informed educational programming has strong potential to improve student safety. Strengthening orientation efforts, clarifying visa-related misconceptions, and increasing resource visibility can help ensure that all students feel empowered and supported in navigating issues related to interpersonal violence.

References

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